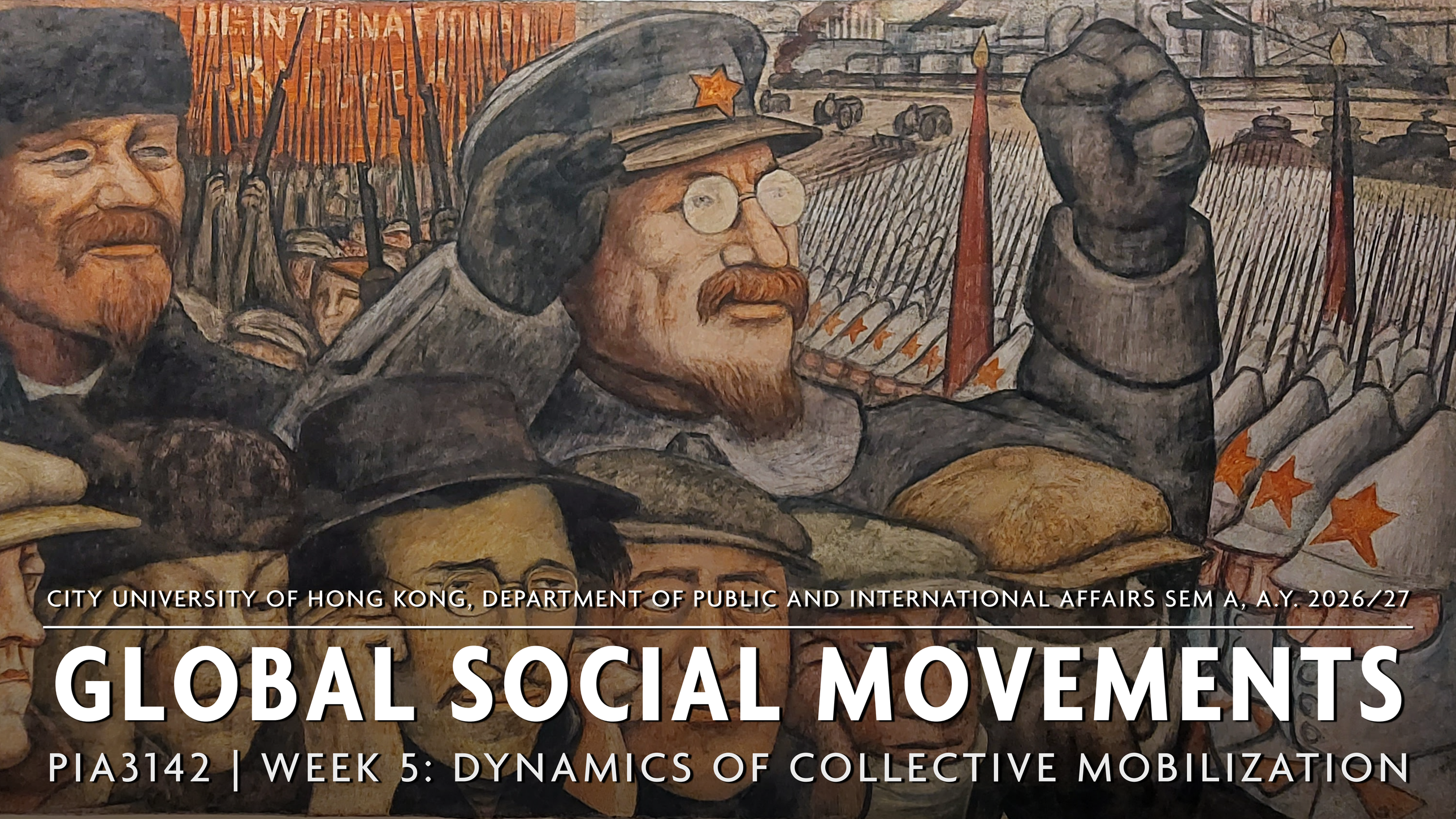


CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

GLOBAL SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

PIA3142 | WEEK 5: DYNAMICS OF COLLECTIVE MOBILIZATION

A DYNAMIC MODEL

Last time, we touched on three points that serve as the basis for today's discussion:

-Effective social movements create their own opportunities;

-Protest is "event-driven:" it is driven by events that are the product of choices, interactions, and chance, so the trajectory that social movements will take and the outcome of their mobilization are not predictable at the outset;

-The job of social movements is to keep the pressure on rivals, push them to make mistakes, and steer the process driven by cycles of action/reaction in the desired direction.

The question for today is whether we can build a model of the "dynamics" of social movement mobilization, combining the "ingredients" we introduced as we searched for a solution to the collective action problem in order to make sense of the interactive and temporal aspects of the mobilization process.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

Of course, social movements vary widely with regard to their goals, the contexts they face, and the identity of their opponents, among other things.

So it's impossible to come up with a single model explaining the dynamics of all social movement mobilization.

The best we can do is perhaps to create a model for an abstract situation with implications for cases in the real world.

So let's assume that the movement we are talking about is a movement for greater freedom and equality, whose enemy is a regime intent on keeping its power (or minimizing concessions).

A DYNAMIC MODEL

In order to achieve its objectives, the movement needs to do two things:

1. Mobilize as many people as possible;

2. Create splits within the regime that cause it to unravel.

Why? Because in the modern world almost all states have a capacity for overwhelming physical force, which makes it impossible for any movement (armed or unarmed) to overpower/overthrow the regime.

Regimes must lose their resolve and/or unravel from the inside.

The basic structure of the model we use today is provided by an article by Rasma Karklins and Roger Petersen ("The Decision Calculus of Protesters and Regimes: Eastern Europe, 1989," Journal of Politics, 1993) on the protests that brought down communist regimes in Eastern Europe in 1989—peacefully, for the most part.

BACKGROUND

These regimes originated in the communist revolution staged in Russia in 1917 and the birth of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) in 1922.

After World War 2, in which the USSR helped the USA/UK defeat Nazi Germany in 1945, Europe was effectively divided into two spheres of influence, as most of Eastern Europe was placed under extremely repressive Soviet-style dictatorship.

The collapse of these regimes in the late 1980s was quite unexpected—the communist bloc was facing economic difficulties, but states seemed very strong and very capable of repression.

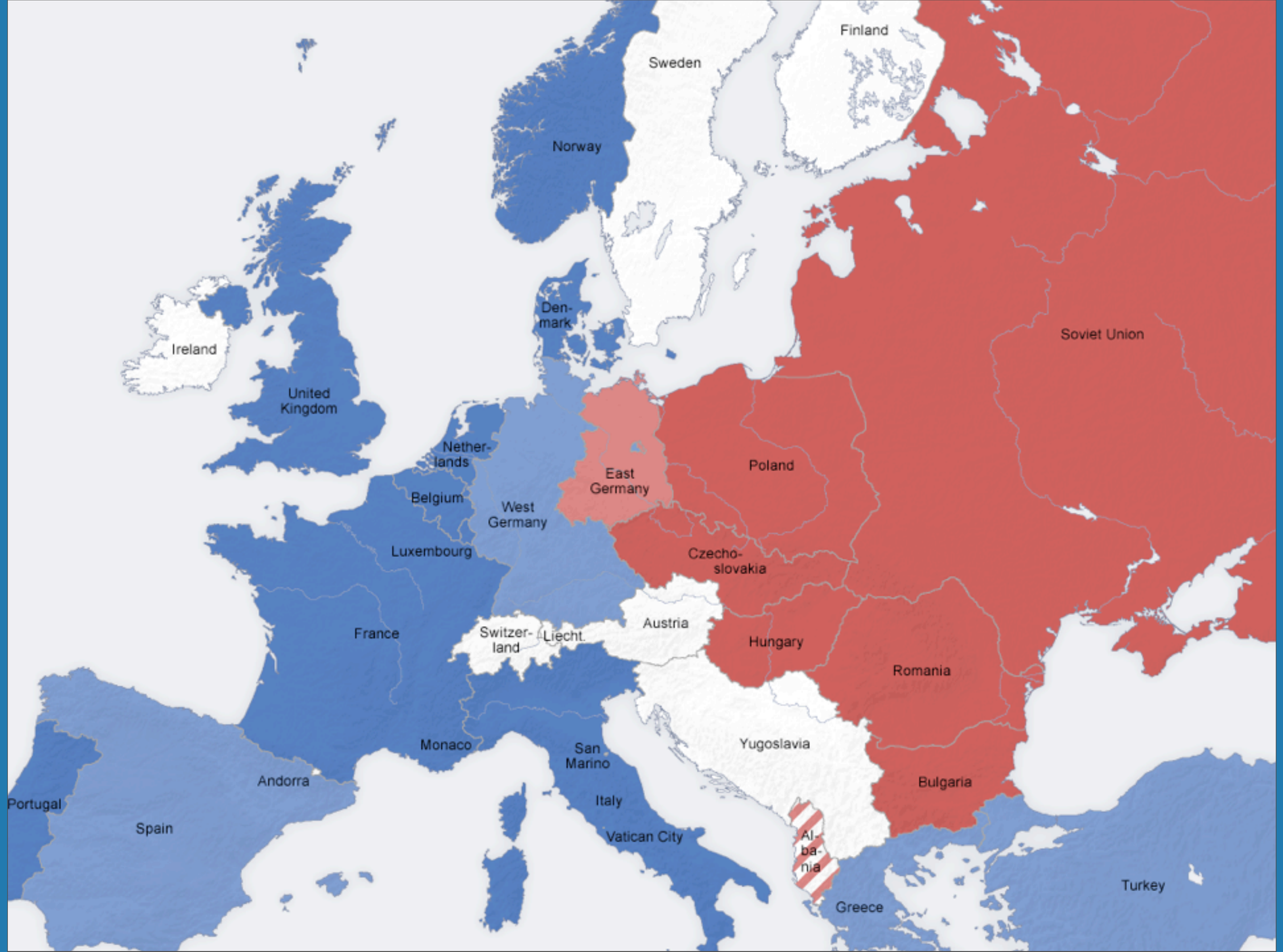
Civil society was extremely weak in most places, after four decades of quasi-totalitarian rule.

Soviet Union Administrative Divisions, 1984



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Finland
Sweden
Norway
Ireland
Den-
mark
Soviet Union
United
Kingdom
Nether-
lands
East
Germany
Poland
Belgium
West
Germany
Luxembourg
Czecho-
slovakia
France
Switzer-
land
Liecht.
Austria
Hungary
Romania
Yugoslavia
Monaco
San
Marino
Bulgaria
Andorra
Portugal
Italy
Spain
Vatican City
Al-
ba-
nia
Turkey
Greece

BACKGROUND

When unrest had taken place in Hungary (1956) and Czechoslovakia (1968), the USSR had intervened militarily. More recently, unrest in various other countries in the Soviet orbit was quashed (e.g., martial law in Poland and banning of "Solidarity" trade union).

One of the turning points was the rise to power in USSR by Mikhail Gorbachev in 1985, who undertook reforms at home and abandoned the Soviet policy of intervening in support of Eastern European regimes threatened by unrest.

After workers' strikes rocked Poland in 1988, the situation snowballed into a series of revolutions in 1989: every Eastern European regime inside the Soviet bloc collapsed within months, either as a result of negotiations between government and opposition (Poland, Hungary, Bulgaria, Czechoslovakia) or the government's overthrow in spontaneous popular uprisings (East Germany, Romania).

BACKGROUND

The collapse of these regimes and the reluctance by the USSR to intervene also emboldened oppositions in many Soviet republics in the Baltic region, the Caucasus, and Central Asia.

By 1990, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Moldova, Armenia, and Georgia declared their independence.

Meanwhile, the reaction to the reforms promulgated in Moscow culminated, in an attempted coup by hardline elements in the Communist Party in August 1991. The coup's failure led to the end of Soviet communism as well as the USSR's break-up into 15 independent countries, most of which adopted democracy and market economies (with varying, and generally disappointing, levels of success).

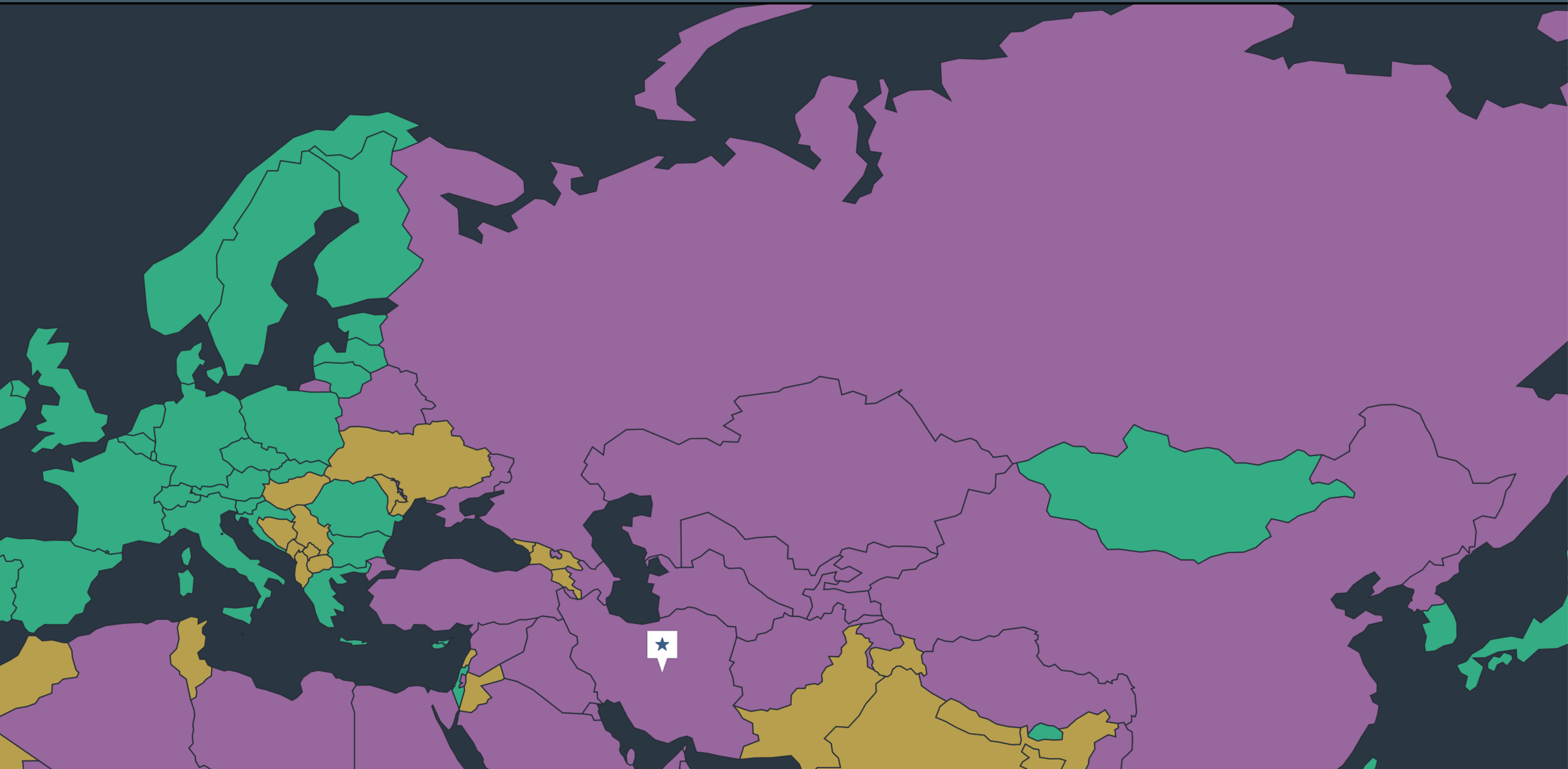
Figure 16. Independent States of the Former Soviet Union



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A DYNAMIC MODEL

In the fall of 1989, the world was astounded by popular mass protests bringing down the Communist regimes of Eastern Europe. While it is understandable that outside observers were caught by surprise, the more intriguing issue is that the most engaged actors on both sides of the political spectrum within the Eastern European states were themselves unprepared for the phenomenon of effective mass protest. When protests began in East Germany and Czechoslovakia in October 1989, neither the dissidents nor regimes expected that they would produce fundamental political change within a few short weeks. Both sides recognized that the tremendous repressive powers of the government were still in place. Just as in the People's Republic of China, these governments had the abilities to physically attack demonstrators and to punish them afterward by denying them jobs, promotions, and other goods, and they were in command of these abilities as late as the summer of 1989. We need to explain how individual citizens made the decision to demonstrate against their powerful governments, we need to explain why the regimes failed to suppress the demonstrations, and we must explain why the process occurred so rapidly and thoroughly.

—Karklins and Petersen (1993)

A DYNAMIC MODEL

Arguably, most theories of rebellious behavior would have failed to predict the outcome. Resource mobilization theories would have pointed to the lack of organizational preconditions for effective protest. Rational Choice theories would have raised the free-rider problem, and relative deprivation theories would have had a difficult time explaining why mass protests started at this particular time and why they recurred with growing numbers day after day.

Tarrow's (1989, 1991) argument that protest has to be analyzed within a broader political opportunity structure would suggest focusing on the consequences of the reformist approach of Gorbachev as well as events in Poland and Hungary. Yet these exogenous influences alone cannot explain the phenomenon of collective action and its role in bringing down the resistant regimes of Czechoslovakia, East Germany, Bulgaria, and Romania. The question we try to answer has been well expressed by Olson (1990, 16): "How can autocratic regimes that appear to have such awesome power over their citizens collapse so quickly?"

—Karklins and Petersen (1993)

A DYNAMIC MODEL

K&P (1993) believe that the answers are to be found in the dynamics of conflict between the communist regimes and their democratic oppositions—i.e., what happened in the event-driven cycle of action/reaction that simultaneously caused the protests gradually to involve more and more constituencies (including some that had previously tended to support the regime) and the regimes to lose the cohesiveness required to deal with the protests decisively (dictators are powerless without the officials who implement their dictates).

How do democratic movements in dictatorships get more and more people to take action and join them? As we have seen, even if protest is relatively free of risk, a self-interested individual should, in most cases, be inclined to stay home —"free ride" and let others do the job.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

The situation is even worse in dictatorships, where institutionalized impunity for human rights abuses and the regime's determination to cling to power leave protesters exposed to violent repression.

This poses a huge problem, especially in the beginning, as the risk of being targeted for repression are much greater when there are few people protesting.

Also, at first there is always great uncertainty about the way the regime will respond and low confidence in the movement's success.

How can a movement persuade someone to "go first"?

A DYNAMIC MODEL

K&P (1993) make the point that the calculus of individual protesters is based on two sorts of considerations:

1. PROTECTION: Protection from physical repression by the regime (so, the size of the protests is key) and protection from social sanction within their "local environment" (i.e., getting shunned by their community, fired from their job, expelled from school)—chances of sanction decrease as more members of their social groups participate.

2. PREDICTION: What are the chances that the regime will collapse? Clues from this come from observing the behavior of different social groups as well as the regime.

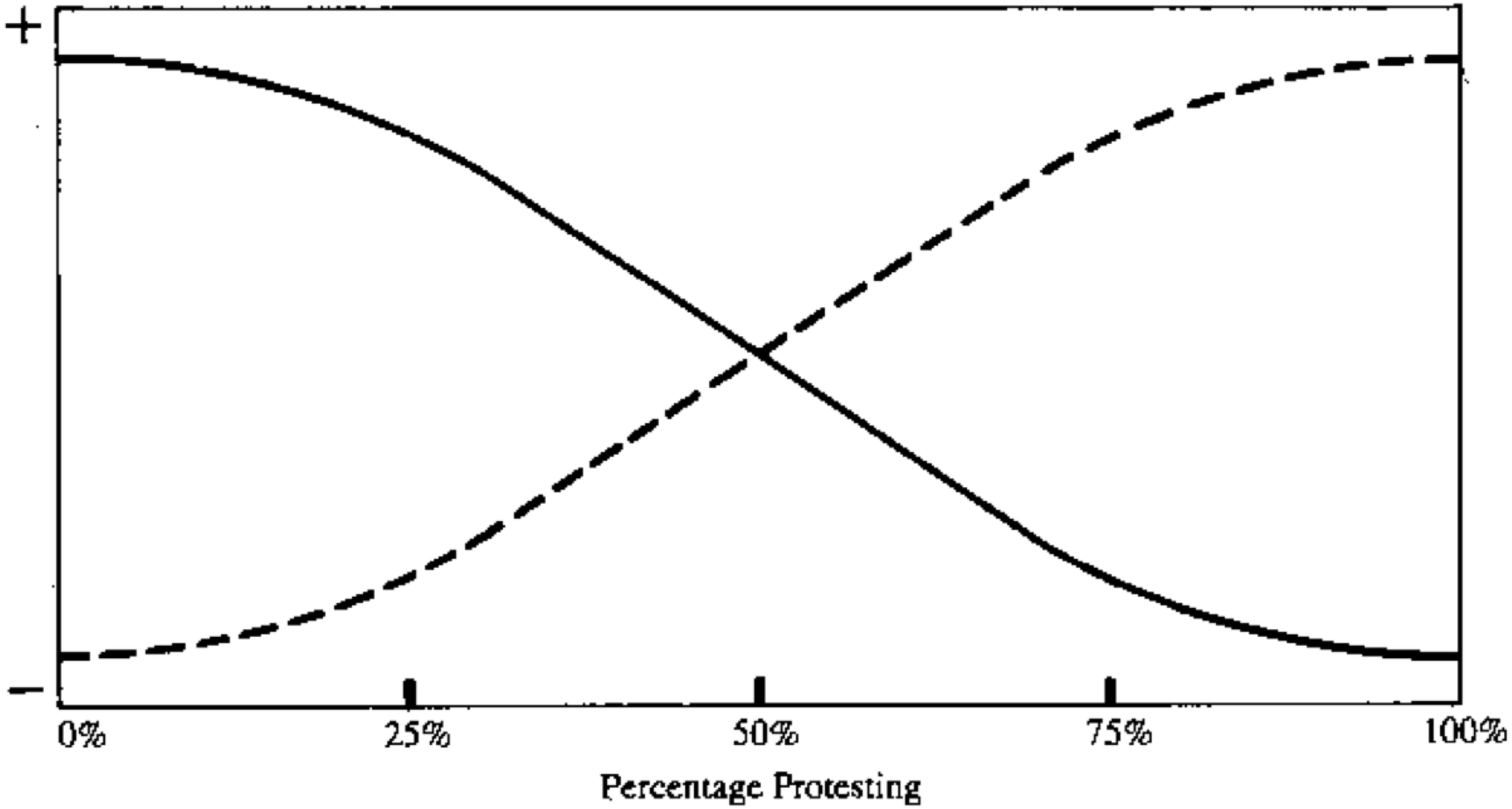
A DYNAMIC MODEL

K&P (1993) illustrate the point with a simple figure showing that, in the calculus of an "average person:"

1. When few people are protesting, the benefits of not demonstrating vastly exceed those of demonstrating;

2. As the number of protesters increases, the difference becomes smaller, until it hits a "tipping point" where demonstrating is better than staying home (e.g., once regime change becomes likely, people might fear consequences of being perceived as a regime supporter or stooge).

Now, if everyone was like this "average person," it would be extremely hard to get any movement going, as nobody would volunteer to go first.


+
−
0%
25%
50%
75%
100%
Percentage Protesting
Utility of Demonstrating
Utility of Not Demonstrating

A DYNAMIC MODEL

Fortunately, for social movements operating in these contexts, the "average person" doesn't exist.

Societies are diverse/heterogeneous, so different kinds of people (based on personal attributes/dispositions, social status/class, and identity) have different incentives and different tolerance for risk.

As a result, these different sorts of people have different "tipping points."

While conceding that societies are complex, K&P (1993) focus on four social groups that were especially important in Eastern Europe at the time:

A DYNAMIC MODEL

1. DISSIDENTS: Known opponents of the regime: they had already been targeted for sanctions by the regime or by their social groups, so they were more willing to step out first because they had the least to lose.

2. STUDENTS: Had more to lose (e.g., because of fear of jeopardizing their careers), so they had a higher tipping point than dissidents.

3. WORKERS: Could be fired from their jobs, so they had a higher tipping point than students.

4. PARTY MEMBERS/SUPPORTERS: Would not demonstrate unless they were sure the regime will fall, so they had the highest tipping point.

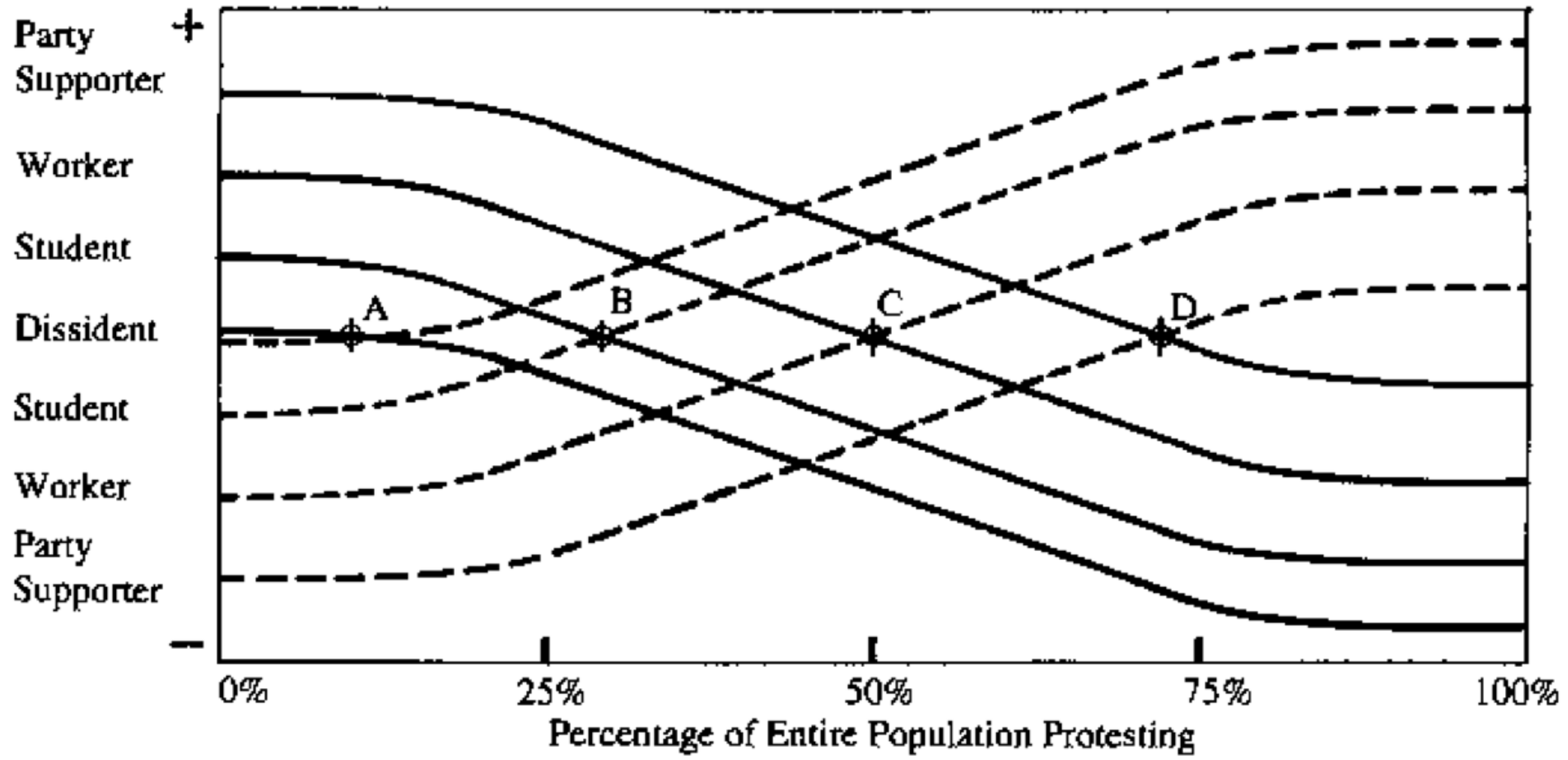
A DYNAMIC MODEL

For the individuals within these groups, what matters is how the participation of others (outside/inside their groups) affects their personal risk and the movement's chances of success.

What is more, the reason why "courage is contagious" is that people's ideas of fairness and their desire for the respect of selves/others can make them want to join when others do, or feel shame for doing nothing, or fear looking bad in the eyes of others.

The importance of these mechanisms should vary with levels of social integration and the strength of collective identities.

Hypothetical Tipping Points for Various Social Groups



A DYNAMIC MODEL

Note that the "tipping points" for the various groups are not fixed at some value. Elements of the context/structure (or the perception of it) can make the tipping points higher/lower:

-Tipping points are higher if individuals see repression as likely (expect lesser protection) and if they predict the regime will not fall.

-Tipping points are lower if individuals see repression as unlikely (expect greater protection) and if they predict the regime might/will fall.

-Tipping points are lowered when there exist stronger "social motivations" to protest and when the movement's resources decrease the logistical costs of protesting.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

The key for a social movement in its early stages is to demonstrate to those staying home that the regime is weak and not willing/able to effectively repress protesters, in the hope of both lowering tipping points for each group and provoking a chain reaction where one group after another reaches its tipping point, causing protests to snowball.

For instance, students are more likely to join protests once it becomes clear that the regime is not able to stop dissidents, which they might interpret as indication that it will not be able to stop them also; workers are more likely to join in when the regime is not able to stop dissidents and students, and so on.

As noted, what else is needed for a democratic movement to succeed is for the regime to unravel.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

K&P (1993) point out that the weakness of dictatorial regimes is rooted in the potential that the perceptions of "guards, officials, and administrators" will change, leading them to refuse to implement orders.

Such changes in perceptions/behavior can be the result of what happens in the streets; the process by which this might happen is in some way similar to the dynamics above.

HOW?

1. Like the general population, "regimes" are internally diverse (different perspectives, motivations, interests, etc.);

A DYNAMIC MODEL

2. Regime officials also base their behavior on their prospects of "protection" (i.e., they do not want to get punished for doing or not doing something) as well as their expectation that the regime they work for will survive or fall;

3. Regime officials also base their decisions on what others in the regime are doing (e.g., a soldier's decision to shoot or not to shoot may be influenced by the behavior of civilian regime officials and other soldiers).

Combining the logics of movement mobilization and regime unravelling, K&P (1993) reach the following conclusion:

A DYNAMIC MODEL

"When the society has a whole has reached the tipping point and is demonstrating day after day without individual fear of physical sanctions, regime officials upgrade the probabilities of regime collapse. When the social groups that have joined the protest process include not only students but workers, soldiers will recalculate the chances of other soldiers firing upon the crowd. In turn, the regime elite will need to recalculate its ability to rely on the soldiers under these new conditions."

A DYNAMIC MODEL

However, K&P (1993) raise two puzzles:

1. Their model still needs a better solution to the collective action problem for those who go first (dissidents may have lower tipping points as a group, but for the first movers among them it is still not instrumentally rational to protest);

2. There is great variation in the effectiveness with which regimes use repression to prevent, stop, or reverse a "bandwagon effect" on protest. Sometimes, repression emboldens protesters; in other cases, it scares them into submission. This is what we'll focus on in Week 7.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

K&P (1993) cite four factors that can help solve these puzzles; the strength of these factors and their combination with one another can dramatically lower tipping points for individuals and groups.

1. Public goods motivations: The presence of individuals driven by public concerns or emotion (leading them to discount private costs of action), or who overestimate the impact of their contribution. These people are needed at early stages of mobilization, as well as at the beginning of each group's involvement. These first movers also influence others, whose public concerns or emotions may create a predisposition for action by reducing the perception of the risks of participating and by increasing social/psychological pressure to participate.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

2. "Informal assembling processes:" Availability of channels of information allowing the coordination of protest activities and the development of common perceptions of events. Aside from organized social movements, informal social ties are key (for reasons related to trust, difficulty in detection).

3. Demonstration effects: In Eastern European countries, this involved looking at what happened in other countries with communist regimes and updating beliefs about the likelihood of repression and the prospects of regime survival, lowering tipping points.

K&P (1993) put these three factors together to explain the mistakes in the regimes' "repressive calculus:" i.e., failure to use the right kind of repression at the right time. Argue that for some Eastern European regimes, the calculus was as follows:

A DYNAMIC MODEL

"At very low levels of protest, use prophylactic repression (control dissident organisational capacities and isolate dissident leaders in order to decapitate potential protest movements); do not use open repression because its deterrent effect is much more powerful if kept in reserve as the uncertainty concerning its use can be as powerful as its actual use. If prophylactic repression fails, use open but limited repression. If protest continues to grow, use open repression before things get out of hand. If demonstrations reach and maintain a level so large that open repression seems infeasible, initiate minor concessions. If protest is unaffected by minor concessions, grant major concessions."

A DYNAMIC MODEL

K&P (1993) say that the strategy was reasonable but failed because it assumed that "repression has a constant meaning" regardless of when it is applied.

In parts of Eastern Europe, the effectiveness of repression was undermined by demonstration effects (i.e., prophylactic repression failed to deter demonstrators because they had seen protesters overcome it elsewhere) as well as by the "informal assembling mechanisms" operating among protesters and the public goods motivations among early protesters.

This was instrumental in getting protest to spread from dissidents to students (lowering their tipping points).

When regimes moved to more incisive repression, they created what K&P (1993) call a "focal event" and backfired.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

K&P (1993) speculate that these regimes might have stayed in power if they had skipped to heavier repression at the beginning, preventing protests from spreading enough to create the perception of regime weakness.

They argue that this is what happened elsewhere (outside Eastern Europe) in 1989, whereas regimes in East Germany and Czechoslovakia only got to use more extreme repression when it was too late: i.e., when repression was perceived more as a sign of desperation than one of strength.

4. Focal events: Expand on this discussion by pointing out that the literature on protest and repression shows that repression can both escalate and de-escalate protest.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

K&P (1993) argue that whether repression leads to more or less protest depends on its timing and the nature of the information it sends to protesters—that is, whether it takes place at a time when it is most likely to unite or divide protesters (leading to shared sense of outrage, urge to strike back) as well as whether it leads protesters to interpret the use of force as a sign of strength or weakness.

In Eastern Europe, K&P (1993) claim that repression came at a time when protest was already too widespread (so, repression was not effective in isolating the group targeted). Also, a regime intent on survival should deal with backlash protest through overwhelming force.

On the contrary, the indecisiveness and the apologies issued by Eastern European regimes in the wake of repression ended up increasing, among protesters and within the regime itself, the perception that the regime had lost the capacity/will to fight.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

In turn, this led protests to increase as well as a breakdown in the cohesiveness of the regime and the discipline within its ranks, which made leaders powerless to issue orders that could have stemmed the tide and left them only with the option of capitulating.

Of course, this is only one model that has a lot of features that are either too abstract or too specifically anchored in a set of cases to apply everywhere.

However, it does suggest an approach that might be useful in explaining the process of conflict in dynamic terms, integrating many of the factors we covered as important to the success of social movements into one framework.

Specifically, it suggests the following steps:

A DYNAMIC MODEL

1. Approaching the process of conflict as a battle between:

(a) Social movements who seek to both create a bandwagon effect for themselves and lead to the unravelling of the other side; and

(b) Opponents that seek to prevent social movement mobilization from growing too large and from undermining their internal cohesiveness/resolve, while seeking to destroy the social movement by demoralising its various components and weakening the solidarity between them.

2. Looking at how the collective action problem is resolved in a gradual fashion, as opposed to all at once, by identifying important groups in society, their interests and worldview, their incentives and constraints, their levels of cohesiveness and integration, their internal diversity with regard to motivations, and ultimately their tipping points for action (what does it take to get them involved?)

A DYNAMIC MODEL

This task requires assessing the importance of structural factors (i.e., understanding how society is organized, how context affects the predisposition of members of different groups to act, as well the manner in which the institutional framework sets opportunities and challenges for social movements) as well as what social movements can do, through their resources, messaging, and activities, to change perceptions of interest, generate emotional urges to act, and foster collective identities.

3. Analyzing the process by which protest spreads (to new constituencies or within constituencies) by identifying mechanisms that make the "contagion" more or less likely.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

4. Asking what tactics social movements can deploy in order to facilitate the contagion by: increasing among potential protesters perceptions of safety from repression and prospects of success; exposing the opponent's weakness; drawing the opponent into making mistakes that provoke outrage among protesters and potential supporters; predisposing supporters to react in similar ways to similar events; fostering a collective identity and the development of a sense of moral obligation between supporters; and undermining the cohesiveness and resolve of the opponents.

5. Asking what tactics the opponents of social movements (governments, corporations, etc.) can use to neutralize their effectiveness in accomplishing the above, as well as to cause social movements to unravel and collapse.

A DYNAMIC MODEL

6. Examining how social movements and their opponents adapt to one another's behavior—i.e., learn from experience and change messaging/tactics to earn and maintain an edge over their competitor.

7. Assessing the importance and effectiveness of each decision in context, allowing for the fact that the effect of any given move varies depending on its timing (when it is made), relative to the overall process of conflict.

Both opponents/supporters interpret the same occurrence differently at different times, as interpretation is inevitably made through the prism of experience. For both participants and observers, the meaning of a set of words/actions/events is only understood and understandable in context; choosing/assessing a course of action or tactic requires expectations about the effects it will have at the time and place it is taken.